

PELICAN BAY POLICE DEPARTMENT
HOMICIDE DIVISION — EIGHTH DISTRICT
715 South Broad Avenue, New Orleans, LA 70119
(504) 658-6080

WITNESS STATEMENT

Case No.: PBPB-2026-034532 | Document No.: 06

Witness Name: DARNELL JAMAL WASHINGTON

DOB / Age / Sex / Race: 07/22/1984 / 41 / Male / Black

Address: 2218 Esplanade Ave., Apt. 4-B, New Orleans, LA 70117

Phone: 504-555-0241

Occupation: Line Cook, Bayou Bistro (714 Bourbon Street)

Date/Time of Statement: October 4, 2025 — 04:12 AM

Location of Interview: PBPB Mobile Unit, scene perimeter

Interviewing Officer: Officer Maria Thibodaux, Badge #2241

Witnessing Officer: Det. Renee Broussard, Badge #1887

Recording: Body-worn camera (BWC-Thibodaux-2025-10-04-001) and audio recorder

The following is a verbatim transcript of the recorded statement of DARNELL WASHINGTON. Statement was taken in question-and-answer format. Witness was advised that he was not being detained and was free to leave at any time. Witness was offered water and a chair. No threats or promises were made.

Q: Mr. Washington, can you state your full name and where you work?

A: Darnell Washington. I cook at Bayou Bistro, the place two doors down. I do the line, mostly the fryer and the grill on weekends. Been there about six years.

Q: What was your shift tonight?

A: I came on at 5 PM. We close the kitchen at 1:30 in the morning but I usually stay until like 2:30, 3, helping break down.

Q: Did you go outside at any point in the early morning hours?

A: Yeah. I go out back to smoke. The alley is where everybody goes — the dishwashers, the bartenders, all of us. I went out probably 2:20 or so. Maybe a couple minutes before that.

Q: Tell me what you saw, in your own words.

A: Okay so I'm standing in the doorway. I got my lighter out. And I hear voices, like, raised. Down the alley toward the south. The Rusty Anchor side. I look over and I see three white dudes and one Black guy. They're like — kinda boxing him in. Not all the way around, but two on one side and one in front. The Black guy is backing up against the wall a little.

Q: How far away were you from this group?

A: I'd say thirty feet, maybe a bit more. There was a light on at my end but their end was dark. I could see shapes more than faces. But I could tell who was who by their shirts.

Q: What were they wearing?

A: The biggest white dude had a red shirt, short sleeves. Real red, like a bar shirt or something. There was another one in a dark hoodie, hood was up partway. And the third was a lighter shirt, like a button-down, like he came from a nicer place. The Black guy had a white t-shirt.

Q: Did you hear what they were saying?

A: I heard pieces. The one in the red shirt was loud. I heard somebody — I think it was the lighter-shirt one — say something like 'you don't know what you're messing with.' Or 'you don't know what you're getting into.' Something like that. The Black guy was saying 'I'm just leaving' or 'I'm walking away.' He was trying to back off.

Q: Did you see any physical contact?

A: Yeah. The red-shirt one shoved him. Two-handed, in the chest. The Black guy stumbled back. That's when I — I kinda backed up into the doorway because I didn't want to get involved, you know? I was reaching for my phone in my pocket. I was gonna call my manager.

Q: Did you make a call?

A: No, sir. Before I could, I heard — there was a sound. Like a thud. I didn't see it because I'd stepped back. And then I heard another one, and I heard somebody say 'Cody, that's enough' or 'Cody, stop.' Loud. Like, scared loud.

Q: Cody?

A: That's what it sounded like. Could've been 'Cory.' But it sounded like 'Cody' to me.

Q: What happened next?

A: I peeked back out and I see the three of them just like running. Running toward Bourbon. The Black guy is on the ground. Just on the ground, not moving. The red-shirt guy was — he had something in his hand. A stick or — I couldn't see exactly. He had it down by his leg as they ran.

Q: A stick like a baseball bat? A pipe?

A: Like a bat, I think. Long, dark colored. Wooden looking. But I'm telling you it was dark down there and they were moving fast.

Q: Did you go check on the man on the ground?

A: I started to. I walked maybe halfway. But there was already somebody there — a lady. Hispanic lady, I think. Short, dark hair. She was standing over him with her phone, like she was calling already. So I just stood there for a second. I — I'll be honest, I was scared too. I didn't know if they were coming back.

Q: What did the woman do?

A: She was on the phone. I heard her speaking — sounded like she was speaking English to whoever was on the line, but kind of accented. She was crying or close to it. Then she just — when she saw me looking she just took off. Walked fast back out to Bourbon and was gone.

Q: Did you recognize any of the three white males?

A: Not their faces clear, no. But the red-shirt guy and the hoodie guy — they look familiar. Like I've seen them around. The Rusty Anchor regulars, you can tell. They come out the back to smoke too sometimes. I couldn't put names on them tonight.

Q: Is there anything else you want to add?

A: Just — the Black guy didn't do anything. He was trying to leave. He was the one being calm. I want that on the record.

Q: Mr. Washington, are you willing to view a photo array if we develop suspects?

A: Yes, sir. I want to help.

END OF STATEMENT — 04:38 AM

Witness reviewed transcript on October 4, 2025 at 11:24 AM and confirmed accuracy. No corrections requested.

Witness Signature: _____ Darnell Washington

Interviewing Officer: _____ Officer M. Thibodaux #2241

Witness to Statement: _____ Det. R. Broussard #1887